BHUPESH KESHARWANI



AGAINST THEIR OWN
A vandalised church in the Bangla Para locality of Narayanpur district

CHHATTISGARH

Tribal Vs Tribal

version of tribal Christians. The party's state president Arun Sao formed a committee of tribal leaders who were to visit the place. However, they were stopped from doing so by the district administration on grounds that the visit would only aggravate matters.

A total of five FIRs have been lodged in connection with the January 2 incident. While the tribal Christians and tribal Hindus involved in the fracas have been booked under relevant sections of rioting, Salam and 11 others face charges for attacks on the church and the SP, including a case of attempt to murder against six.

Reports had started trickling in from the third week of December of selective attacks on Christian tribal converts across villages in the Narayanpur district. The attacks were similar in origin in most cases—beginning as altercations over some members of the tribal community following Christian rituals and customs. Christian tribal converts were attacked, their houses damaged and their belongings thrown outside. So much so that nearly 400 displaced people from six villages entered the premises of the district collectorate, seeking refuge there.

The incidents did not go unnoticed among the Christian community in other parts of the country. A fact-finding team, constituted by the United Christian Forum (UCF), visited the affected areas. "Nearly 1,000 tribal Christians, including women and children, have been chased out of their homes. In fact, they are under threat to convert to Hinduism," read a release from A.C. Michael, president of the Federation of Catholic Associations of the Archdiocese of Delhi, demanding action by the Union ministry of minority affairs.

THE RULING CONGRESS HAS BLAMED THE BJP, WHICH HAS DISTANCED ITSELF FROM THE ATTACKS

Political observers, however, feel the local Congress government's response to the incidents has been defensive. That the BJP has been trying to bring the issue of conversions to the fore in Chhattisgarh seems evident from the importance being given to certain leaders in the tribal belt. Both Salam and former Narayanpur BJP president Narayan Markam have been brought centrestage. They were both associated with a body that has been working on issues like conversion for some years. In the 2018 assembly election, the Congress had won 11 of the 12 seats in the Bastar region. The party also wrested the lone seat that went to the BJP later in a byelection.

The police on their part deny that